

Even in such sadness, Elizabeth looked calm. She spoke clearly and listened carefully. When given official papers, she read them quickly, remembering everything. After all, she was to be queen not just of the UK, but of the entire Commonwealth.

After her father's funeral came plans for her coronation—and a new era. There was much to learn. Elizabeth was never late, never impatient, and did not appear to worry.

THE COMMONWEALTH

The Commonwealth is a group of nations that grew from the old British Empire. When Elizabeth became queen, the Commonwealth had 650 million people. Today, it has 2.4 billion citizens. Member states help each other through various organizations. Elizabeth valued being the symbolic head of this “family” of free nations.

She has visited almost all 54 Commonwealth countries and counts many of their leaders as friends.



Flag of the
Commonwealth
of Nations